

World in Brief: Russia and Ukraine against the grain; White House accuses China of evading tariffs



Photograph: Getty Images

Russian drones caused a fire and damage at Izmail, a grain export hub and **Ukraine's** largest Danube port. The attack follows a big Ukrainian strike on Novorossiysk, one of Russia's most strategically important ports on the Black Sea, which hit a naval base and two grain terminals. At least three people, including a child, were killed. The attacks have stoked fears of disruption to global food supplies.

The **White House** accused **China** of evading [American tariffs](#) by rerouting exports through more than 40 countries. It said other nations subject to high tariffs are doing something similar. The Trump administration estimates that “the great transshipment scam” will cost the government up to \$26bn in annual tax revenue. It is developing an AI-powered “detective border” to catch tariff-dodgers.

Israeli troops launched a military operation to remove Israeli settlers from Qusra, a village in the **West Bank**. The [settlers](#) had besieged the homes of several Palestinian families and an American citizen, cutting off access to food, water and electricity. Mike Huckabee, America's ambassador to Israel, condemned the settlers

as “terrorists”. Taybeh, another West Bank village, was closed to non-residents last week following similar attacks.

A federal judge in Boston dismissed the Trump administration’s **antisemitism lawsuit** against **Harvard University**. The lawsuit alleged that the university allowed discriminatory behaviour during student protests against Israel’s war in Gaza. The judge said the incidents were “too isolated and episodic” to prove a violation of civil-rights law. The administration has repeatedly **bashed Harvard**, which it sees as a hotbed of antisemitism and left-wing indoctrination.

Romania began shutting down its last working **nuclear reactor** as water levels in the Danube fell to a record low. The state-owned power plant relies on river water to cool its reactors. Another Romanian reactor shut down in late July for the same reason. The European country has declared a state of energy emergency; Hungary and France have also reduced their nuclear-power output.

Britain and parts of Europe sweltered under **heatwaves** once more. Britain had its hottest day of the year so far, with temperatures reaching 38.1°C in some areas. Parts of the country had large grass fires. Meanwhile EDF, France’s state-owned electricity group, warned that high temperatures would slash the country’s nuclear-power production by 15% on Friday. Europe is **warming faster** than any other continent.

Miguel Díaz-Canel, **Cuba’s** president, called Fidel Castro “a guide for overcoming the challenges before us today” at a commemoration of the centenary of the Communist revolutionary’s birth. Those **challenges are great**: decades of mismanagement and a tightening embargo by America have crippled the island economically and its people face privation. But more Marxist dogma is unlikely to alleviate their suffering.

Figure of the day: 27%, the rise in omelette sales at eateries close to the venues of Taylor Swift concerts in Miami in 2024. Read how data analysis, AI and robots are [transforming the restaurant business](#).

The US in Brief: Trump renews attack on mail-in ballots



Photograph: Getty Images

The Trump administration asked the **Supreme Court** to allow it to direct the United States Postal Service to oversee **mail-in ballots**. Mr Trump has falsely linked their use to fraudulent voting. It is the second time the president has asked the justices to intervene over an executive order that he signed in March and which was quickly challenged in court. In June a federal judge blocked it in 23 states, and this week expanded that decision to be nationwide.

Karoline Leavitt will resign as the **White House press secretary** this month to spend more time with her children, Mr Trump said. The president said she will become one of his “top outside advisers” and be an “influential voice” within the Republican Party. Ms Leavitt, who was 27 when she assumed office last year, is the youngest person to have held the role.

The **Justice Department** charged 11 people for running a scheme that arranged **marriages** designed to help foreigners gain permanent residency. The group is accused of setting up more than 1,000 weddings over a decade, mostly for Chinese citizens seeking green cards. The Trump administration has also recently tried to crack down on “birth tourism”, where people try to ensure citizenship for their child by travelling to America to give birth, which it alleges is open to “fraudulent activity”.

Critics condemned plans to equip **Immigration and Customs Enforcement** agents with taser-like **electric-shock gloves** designed to stun. They worry that the weapons will make officers more likely to use force. A former acting director of ICE warned that it is “too easy” for the gloves to be “misused”. The American Civil Liberties Union said that, given the agency’s record of excessive force, the gloves are “a recipe for more harm to the public”.

Max Miller, a Republican congressman from Ohio, was sued by his ex-wife for releasing a nude image of their two-year-old daughter. Emily Moreno alleges that Mr Miller “recklessly” published the image, which was in documents he and his lawyer had collected as they fight accusations of domestic abuse Ms Moreno has levelled against him. Mr Miller posted the files on social media after a broadcasting a livestream professing his innocence. He said the photo’s release was “completely unintentional”.

Mr Trump was sued over a plan by **Truth Social**, [his social-media platform](#), to sell earlier access to his market-moving posts for up to \$100,000 a month. The Intercept, a news site, and the Freedom of the Press Foundation, an advocacy group, called the scheme “profoundly corrupt” in their complaint. The White House has denied that the arrangement poses a conflict of interest.

America’s annual inflation rate slowed from 3.5% to 3.4% in July, in line with analysts’ expectations. Core inflation, which excludes food and energy prices, slid from 2.6% to 2.5%. The Federal Reserve has faced calls to raise interest rates in response to inflationary pressures caused by the Iran war. The data will buoy Mr Trump, who wants lower rates.

Figure of the day: 46%, the share of Democrats who have lost a relationship with a friend, family member or romantic partner because of political differences. The share for Republicans is 29%. [Read the full story.](#)

Britain's oddest by-election

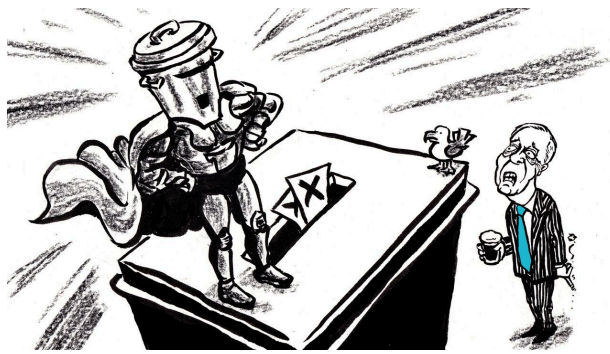


Illustration: David Simonds

On Thursday Nigel Farage, the leader of Reform UK, a populist-right party, will seek to be re-elected as the MP for Clacton in an election only taking place because he resigned that same seat in July. He claimed that the best way to resolve persistent questions about the source of some of his income was for voters in the Essex town to decide whether he should continue to serve in Parliament.

Mr Farage is almost certain to win, but that won't provide a ringing endorsement. All the other main parties are sitting out the by-election, which they say is a farce. It is. Of the 33 other candidates (a record for a British by-election), the main challenger seems to be [Count Biface](#), the alter-ego of a comedian; an opinion poll suggests he could pick up 20% of the vote. A hefty victory will not solve Reform's broader problems, either. It has fallen behind the ruling Labour Party in polls and investigations into its financing will continue.

Maersk weathers the storm



Photograph: Getty Images

Early in the year A.P. Moller-Maersk spied trouble ahead. An industry-wide ordering spree of new vessels in recent years, the Danish container-shipping giant warned, would drive shipping rates down through overcapacity. Yet merrily Maersk sails along. The firm reported strong second-quarter results on Thursday, with a 20% year-on-year increase in revenue, to \$15.8bn. It upgraded its guidance for a second time this year: it had hoped for \$2bn-4bn in operating profit, now it expects \$4.5bn-6.5bn.

That is because, so far, [geopolitical disruptions](#) have been good for Maersk. The threat of new rounds of American tariffs, including those which kicked in in July, boosted demand for shipping in the quarter as American companies rushed to stock up on goods. In time, however, if the shipping route through the Red Sea reopens, overcapacity may start to weigh on rates. And persistent inflation could dampen the consumer demand that keeps the industry afloat. It won't be plain sailing forever.

Zambia's regressing reformer



Photograph: Getty Images

The victory of Hakainde Hichilema in Zambia's presidential election in 2021 was meant to be the moment the country turned a corner. The previous government had defaulted on its debts, allowed inflation to soar and let thuggish party cadres shake down traders at city markets.

Five years on in copper-rich Zambia, and [its economy](#) is back on track, boosted by record copper prices. New policies such as free education are popular. No wonder Mr Hichilema is the favourite to win a second term in Thursday's election. But anxieties about the cost of living persist, and have energised the campaign of Brian Mundubile, his main challenger. Nearly two-thirds of Zambians live on less than \$2.15 a day. Meanwhile the president's democratic credentials have been damaged: cyber-crime laws have muzzled critics, and some opposition parties have been prevented from fielding candidates. Mr Hichilema was once imprisoned on trumped up charges for standing up to overweening power. Now he is the one who wields it.



Growing riches

Copper, \$'000 per metric tonne



Source: Bloomberg

A new boss for Hugo Boss?



Photograph: Reuters

Shareholders of [Hugo Boss](#), Germany's biggest luxury fashion firm, must decide whether to accept a takeover offer from Mike Ashley, a bolshy British retail tycoon, on Thursday. In June Mr Ashley put forward a €2bn (\$2.3bn) cash bid for the 74% of Hugo Boss's shares he did not already own. The board deemed it too low, and recommended that shareholders not accept his offer of €38 a share.

When Daniel Grieder, the company's boss, assumed his post in 2021, he took a belt-and-braces approach, adding modern, trend-driven collections alongside the firm's more traditional tailoring. Sales almost doubled within four years. But that momentum has stopped: sales fell to €905m in the second-quarter of 2026, 9% lower than a year earlier; operating profits dropped by 14%. [Mr Ashley spies a deal](#). By the end of July his company, Frasers Group, owned 37.5% of Hugo Boss. It may soon be another label in his wardrobe of brands.

Wagner's mighty saga



Photograph: Marc Brenner/Grange Park Opera

Thursday is the 150th anniversary of the first full performance of the “Ring” cycle by Richard Wagner, among the most ambitious works of theatre ever created. It took place at an opera house he had built for the purpose, in Bayreuth, Germany. Wagner not only wrote the music for the [15-hour-long series](#) of four “music dramas” but the words. The story, based on Germanic and Scandinavian legends, tells of the theft of a ring that gives its wearer world-ruling power and of a curse laid upon it, which leads to the destruction of the gods.

People who haven’t experienced the “Ring” have felt its influence. It was an inspiration for “The Lord of the Rings”, and everyone has heard “The Ride of the Valkyries”. Reaching back to a mythic past and pointing towards an unknowable future, the “Ring” illuminates the human condition and the contemporary one. But stagings that comment on the present don’t always work. Bayreuth’s anniversary production uses artificial intelligence as an “image-generating force”. Audiences have booed.

Daily Quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Thursday: Which civil rights leader was baptised with the name of Michael, only to have his name changed by his father at the age of five?

Wednesday: Who directed the first two Harry Potter films?

*To make the public sentiment, on
the side of all that is just and true
and noble, is the highest use of
life.*

Lucy Stone